

Being a DPO in a **Complex Organization**

Ghent University



Table of contents

Introduction..... 03

1. Getting a grip 04

2. Assigning responsibility 05

3. Setting priorities 06

4. Delegating wisely 08

5. Staying ahead of new technology 09

Conclusion 11



Introduction

No two complex organizations are alike, but the challenges their DPOs face tend to rhyme. Too many departments to map, too many processing activities to track, and never quite enough hours in the week.

This guide draws on Responsum's webinar ***Being a DPO in a Complex Organization*** with Bart van Buitenen and Hanne Elsen, Data Protection Officer at Ghent University, one of the largest and most structurally complex organizations in Belgium, spanning research, student housing, international campuses, spin-offs, and centuries of institutional history.

Rather than a checklist of GDPR articles, this is a practical account of how one DPO actually built grip in a sprawling organization: how she found her people, distributed responsibility without losing control, decided what to work on first, learned when not to be involved, and kept pace with AI without becoming the university's unofficial AI compliance department.

If you work in a large, decentralized, or historically layered organization (a hospital, a public institution, a multinational, a university) the patterns in this guide will likely feel familiar.



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Getting a grip: networks before frameworks

Every DPO arriving in a large organization faces the same first problem: where do you even start? For Hanne, the register of processing activities was a useful starting point, but only a starting point. The real turning point was talking directly to the people already handling privacy questions as part of their own job, long before she arrived.

From there, informal contact grew into something more structural: recurring meetings with data stewards, legal teams, and DPOs from partner institutions. What began as “getting to know each other” evolved into standing governance bodies, while she deliberately never abandoned the one-on-one relationships that made the network trustworthy in the first place. She’s also clear about her personal preference, even in a post-COVID, remote-first world: physical meetings still beat digital ones for building the kind of trust that makes a network actually work.

Takeaway: *A register of processing activities gives you data. A network gives you access. Build both, but build the relationships first, because that’s what makes the framework usable later.*

Assigning responsibility: from policy to practice

A DPO cannot personally own compliance across every department, project, and research group. At Ghent University, the anchor point isn't a public-facing privacy statement, but an internal **code of conduct** for processing personal and confidential data. The code of conduct itself doesn't explain how to be compliant. Hanne is upfront that, like most internal regulations, it's "not a very life or vivid document." Its value lies elsewhere: it makes unmistakably clear that GDPR compliance is not something you outsource to the DPO by email, but something built into everyone's daily tasks. From that foundation, responsibility gets distributed through concrete mechanisms:

- **Owners of tools:** individuals accountable for keeping the register up to date for the processing activities under their control.
- **Quality gates:** GDPR checkpoints embedded into existing approval flows: no research ethics clearance, no contract, and no IT project sign-off without a GDPR check first.

"The quality of your lock depends on who knows how the door should be opened and kept closed."

– Hanne Elsen



- **Divide and conquer:** data stewards, legal, and the DPO's office each carry a piece of the support structure, rather than funneling every question to one inbox.

Crucially, these quality gates only work if the people staffing them actually understand what they're checking for.

***Takeaway:** A policy that assigns responsibility without training people to carry it out is just a signature on a document. Pair every quality gate with the expertise to use it.*

CHAPTER 3

Setting priorities: the yearly report as your compass

Ask any DPO in a complex organization what their to-do list looks like, and the honest answer is: endless. Hanne is candid that a fixed annual list to simply work through, undisturbed, is "a dream", not reality. At Ghent University, the annual report is more than a look back. It documents incidents, DPIAs, and advice given (followed or not), which makes it an accountability instrument. But its second, arguably more important function is forward-looking: it sets out, in a concrete table, what the DPO intends to prioritize in the year ahead, sent to the board for acknowledgement, not approval.

That distinction matters. The board doesn't sign off on the plan; they take note of it. But having it on the record gives Hanne something to point back to when trade-offs need to be made, including telling researchers, colleagues, or even the rector that certain individual requests will simply take longer, because higher-risk work takes

precedence. It also keeps her honest about her own effectiveness: putting out individual fires feels productive day to day, but it isn't the same as making progress on the priorities that actually move the university forward.

"I try to spend my time based on what's most priority for the university and not because there is a deadline or an individual deadline."

— Hanne Elsen



Takeaway: *A yearly report isn't paperwork, it's leverage. Documented, board-acknowledged priorities give you a legitimate basis to say no to lower-priority requests without it looking arbitrary.*

Delegating wisely: not everything belongs on the DPO's desk

Nothing in the GDPR requires every data subject request to land on the DPO's desk, and at Ghent University, most of them don't. Part of that is architecture: students can access much of their own data directly through self-service portals, removing the need for a formal request in the first place. For the requests that do reach her, Hanne draws a clear line between advice and execution. She reviews and verifies requests and gives guidance on what should happen, but the actual retrieval and disclosure of data stays with the people who hold and understand it, department by department. It's the same model used in hospitals, where doctors and nurses (not the DPO) handle access requests to medical files, because they're trained to do it safely.

"I don't want access and I don't want the data and I don't want to be some sort of a collector."

— Hanne Elsen



There are exceptions. When a request is sensitive, or entangled in a broader conflict between the data subject and the institution, Hanne will take a more active role: partly because an external, independent DPO can feel like a safer point of contact than someone embedded in the department the person has an issue with.

Takeaway: *Delegating execution doesn't mean losing oversight. Keep the advisory role, hand off the operational one, and reserve direct involvement for the genuinely sensitive cases.*

CHAPTER 5

Staying ahead of new tech: AI as a governance problem, not a DPO problem

When AI adoption accelerated at the university, Hanne made a deliberate choice: she did not turn herself into the university's AI compliance officer, even as she acknowledges plenty of DPOs elsewhere are moving that direction. Instead, the existing privacy governance body was widened in scope.

"AI is going way faster than we are."

– Hanne Elsen



The Commission on Privacy and Data Protection became the Commission on Privacy, Artificial Intelligence and Data Protection, with AI-related personal data questions folded into its existing mandate. Hanne sits on it, but doesn't run it. On the ground, the same quality-gate logic from Chapter 2 gets extended: funding and procurement questionnaires that already ask "does this involve GDPR?" now also ask "does this involve AI?" – a distinct, more nuanced question that helps route issues to the right expertise without requiring the DPO to become an AI specialist overnight.

Takeaway: *You don't need to own every new compliance frontier personally. Extend your existing governance structures to cover it, stay embedded as an advisor, and resist the pressure to absorb every adjacent responsibility into the DPO role.*



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Conclusion

Being a DPO in a complex organization isn't about eliminating chaos, it's about building enough structure that chaos stops being a daily emergency.

Across this conversation, a few threads repeat:

- **Relationships come before frameworks.** A register of processing activities only becomes useful once you know who to call.
- **Responsibility has to be distributed, not just documented.** Codes of conduct and quality gates only work if the people staffing them are trained and supported.
- **Priorities need to be written down and shared upward.** A yearly report, acknowledged by the board, gives you the standing to say no.
- **Not every DPO task needs the DPO.** Delegate execution, keep advice, and reserve direct involvement for genuinely sensitive situations.
- **New risk areas like AI don't require a new job title.** Extend existing governance rather than adding every emerging topic to your own plate.

None of this makes the work smaller. But it makes it sustainable, and it gives you something concrete to show a supervisory authority, a board, or your own team when they ask how decisions actually get made.



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